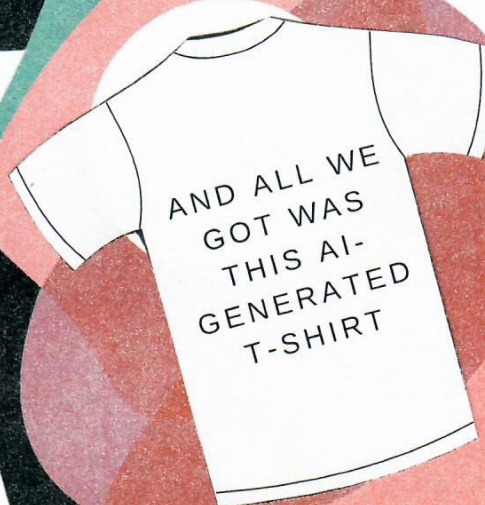


Dimensions Colliding:



Zine's Purpose

From 2024-2025, we engaged in an undergraduate research project focused on digital reparative archives, maker culture and zines (Reparative Archives Zotero Group, 2024), and the cultural implications of Artificial Intelligence. A central question continued to resurface: what will happen to humanity's sense of community as AI locks individuals into solitary digital bubbles? AI's affordances allow it to be a surrogate for human connection, drastically altering humanity's trust in technology, cultural thinking, and social media. As AI expands into more use cases across domestic and professional life, we must evaluate AI's potential impact before it dominates our engagement within communities.

Our Definition of Artificial Intelligence

Artificial Intelligence in this zine refers to language models. This evaluation of AI within community spaces is intended to demonstrate the potential dangers of AI within these spaces. AI is a necessary tool in many spaces, specifically STEM research. AI can also be a wonderful tool for people who may not have access to other resources. We are in no way attempting to say all Artificial Intelligence is inherently negative. Instead, we want to shine a light on how AI has intruded into communal spaces.

SOCIAL CLIMATE

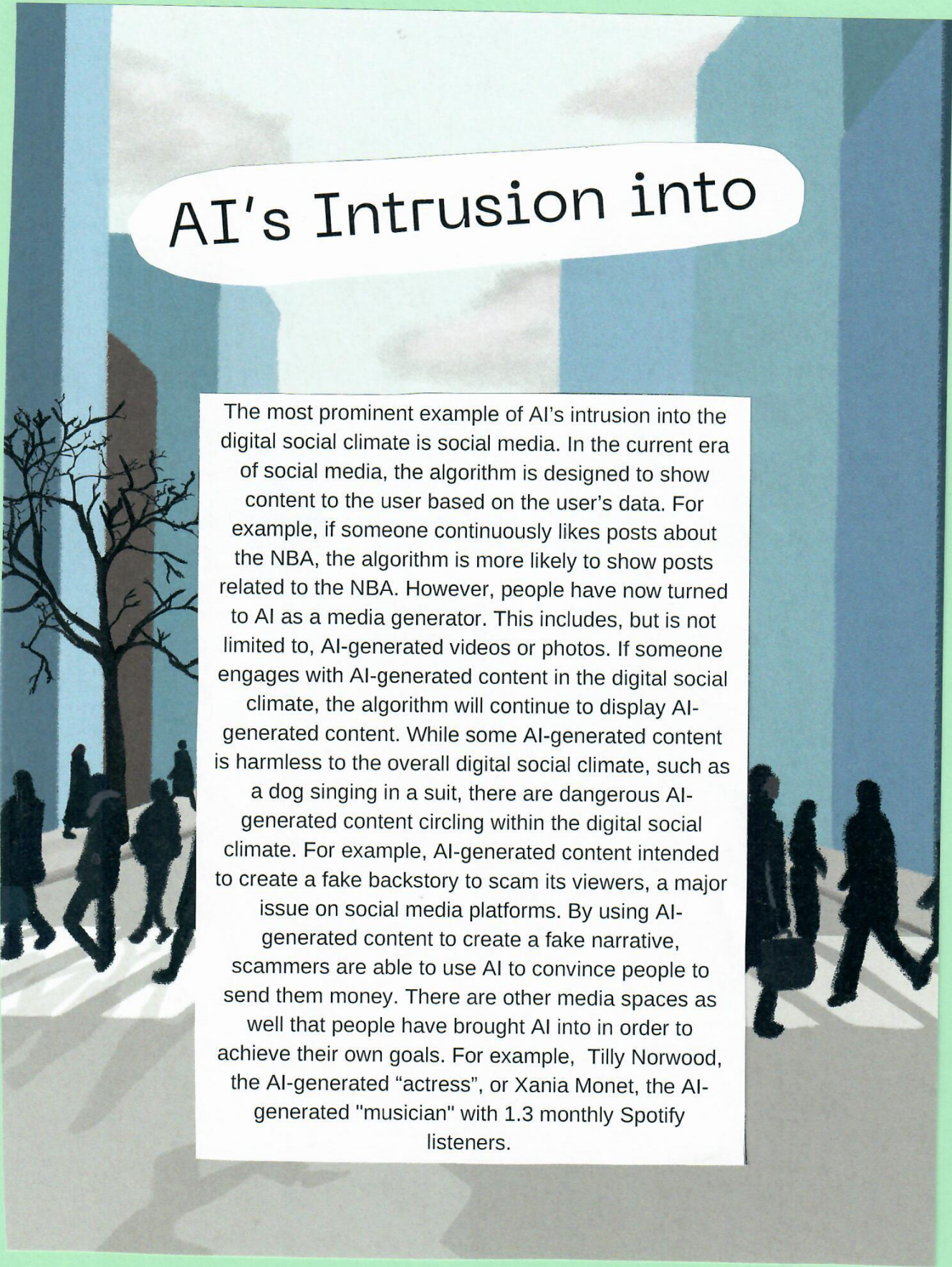
Social climate refers to shared perceptions of beliefs about a social environment held by a group of people (Bennett, 2010). The foundation for the social climate is human connection. Some examples of the social climate include religious spaces, work out classes, school, and in-person work spaces.

DIGITAL CLIMATE

Digital climate refers to a space where people's shared perceptions, attitudes, and behaviors towards digital technologies are shaped by digital infrastructures (Avtalion et al, 2024). The digital climate is grounded in a data-driven culture. A data-driven culture refers to the digital climate being shaped by data. An example of this would be searching for a banana bread recipe online. The five-star recipe that is clicked on the most will be at the top of the search bar due to the data configured by search engines.

DIGITAL SOCIAL CLIMATE

Digital Social Climate is a newly emerged third space where perceptions or beliefs can reconfigure how people interact, collaborate, engage, and innovate. Similarly to the social climate and digital climate, the digital social climate has a foundation of human connection and data-driven culture. With this foundation, the third space has become extremely complex. A key aspect of the third space is users' digital consciousness or their understanding of digital technologies (Avtalion et al, 2024). For historical context, this third space was created with the first social media platform Six Degrees in 1997. For almost 30 years, the digital social climate has been a space for people to have community, especially during the COVID-19 pandemic. However, the community within this space can be extremely isolating because it is based on data. For example, people may believe the crochet community is larger than it is because online they are in a crochet community. They may have joined the crochet community by engaging with posts online leading to more posts about crocheting. While this is a low consequence example of data-driven culture, it demonstrates the dangers of the digital social climate creating false realities for its users. But how does AI relate to this space?



AI's Intrusion into

The most prominent example of AI's intrusion into the digital social climate is social media. In the current era of social media, the algorithm is designed to show content to the user based on the user's data. For example, if someone continuously likes posts about the NBA, the algorithm is more likely to show posts related to the NBA. However, people have now turned to AI as a media generator. This includes, but is not limited to, AI-generated videos or photos. If someone engages with AI-generated content in the digital social climate, the algorithm will continue to display AI-generated content. While some AI-generated content is harmless to the overall digital social climate, such as a dog singing in a suit, there are dangerous AI-generated content circling within the digital social climate. For example, AI-generated content intended to create a fake backstory to scam its viewers, a major issue on social media platforms. By using AI-generated content to create a fake narrative, scammers are able to use AI to convince people to send them money. There are other media spaces as well that people have brought AI into in order to achieve their own goals. For example, Tilly Norwood, the AI-generated "actress", or Xania Monet, the AI-generated "musician" with 1.3 monthly Spotify listeners.



Communal Spaces

AI's intrusion into the digital social climate has created a drastic shift in humanity's trust in technology. This phenomenon is exacerbated by people's use of AI for therapeutic purposes. AI has begun replacing human therapists via online chatbots such as ChatGPT or Abby the AI Therapist (Holohan, M., & Fiske, A., 2021). Through engaging in a human-like discussion with AI, AI therapists demonstrate how AI is transitioning from a tool utilized by humans to a collaborator (Riva, G., 2025). Furthermore, humanity is no longer engaging with digital consciousness as many people unconsciously view the AI therapists as a conscientious being.

Similarly to humanity's trust in technology, a drastic change has occurred in cultural thinking. Neurological research illustrates that humanity is risking losing the ability for face-to-face interactions, creativity, and innovation. The research ultimately highlights the importance of preserving humanity's social capacities when engaging with digital technology (Riva, G., 2025). In essence, the research pushes the idea that people do not necessarily have to utilize their human social abilities to survive, the same way humanity no longer has to hunt and gather for survival.

Interviews



ChatBox



Ambient.ai



synthesia

We interviewed four people for this Zine. Although this is not an official study, the interviews offer insight into how different generations perceive community and AI. To ensure their privacy, each interviewee was assigned a unique archetype.

First, the Ultimate Maker and Cultivator is from the Silent Generation with very limited knowledge of digital technologies. Second, The Tired Millennial is someone who grew up with the age of technology. Next, is The Coder, a recent college graduate from Gen Z who relies on technology for his profession. Lastly, Technology's Princess is a young girl from Gen Alpha.



OpenAI



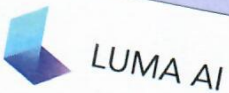
regie.ai



Mentum



oPRO.ai



We asked each interviewee the following questions:

1. Can you tell us about something you've made, created, or worked on recently?
2. What technology or digital platforms do you use most often in your everyday life?
3. When you hear the term "Artificial Intelligence," what comes to mind?
4. What has your experience been like interacting with AI tools or chatbots?
5. How do you think AI affects connection and community in digital spaces, or in-person spaces?

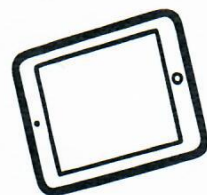
The Ultimate
Maker &
Cultivator

1941



The Coder

2003



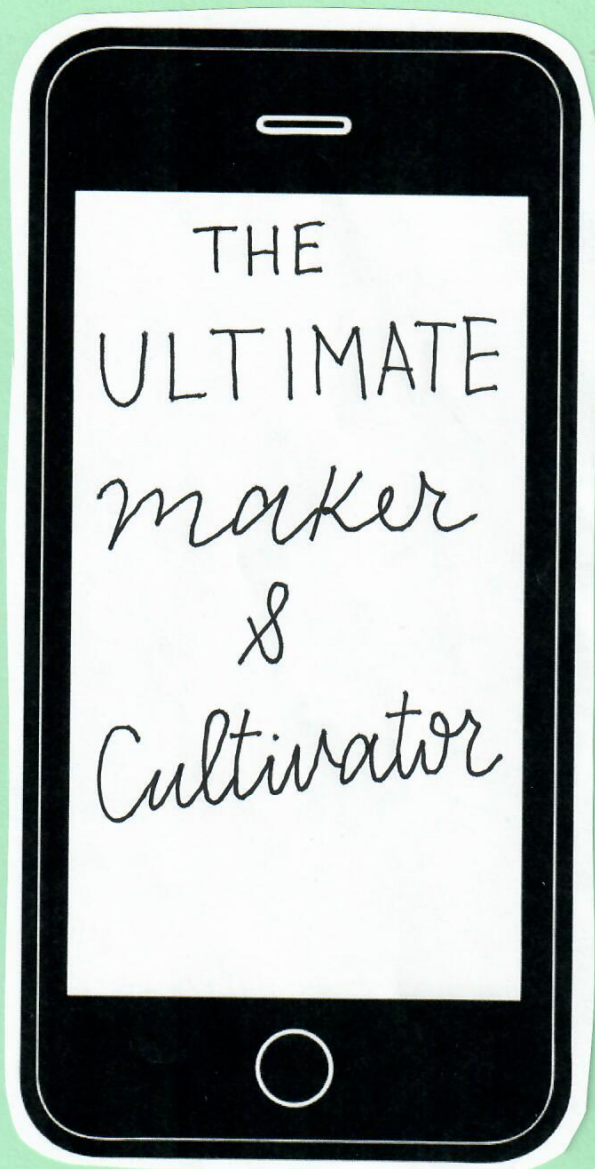
1989

The Tired
Millennial



2016

Technology's
Princess



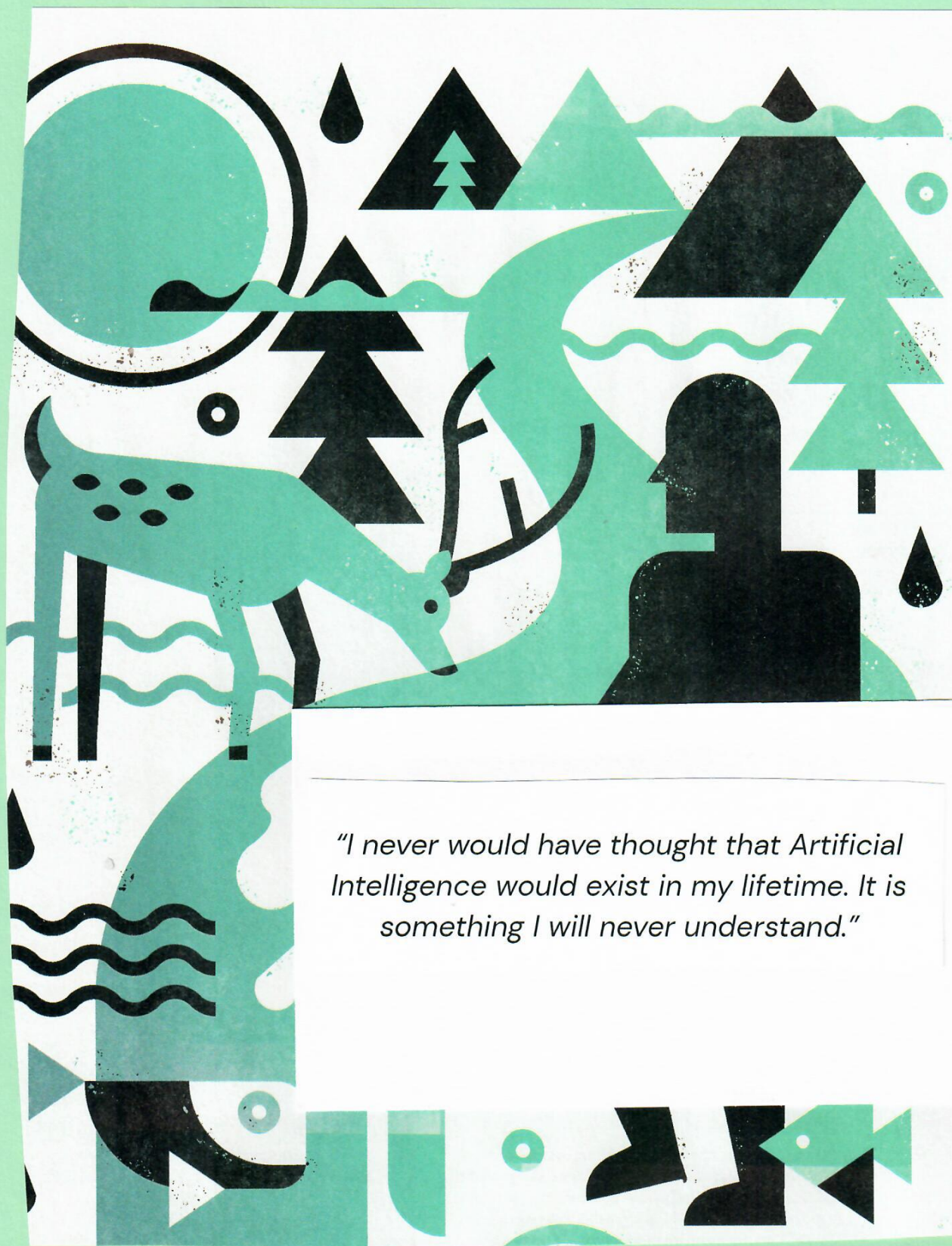
The Ultimate Maker and Cultivator is an 85 year old woman.

While she understands how to fix the AC in her house on her own, she struggles with any form of smart phone.

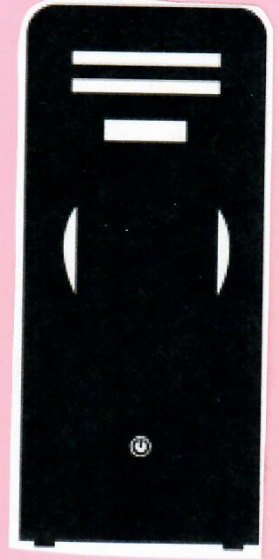
She utilizes a television the most in her daily life to watch old western movies. The Ultimate Maker & Cultivator feels lost with technology. She never focused on learning how to use it during her youth because she did not think it would become this crucial in daily life. She is grateful to have people to help her when she needs to use technology. The Ultimate Maker and Cultivator has never interacted with AI in her life, as far as she knows.



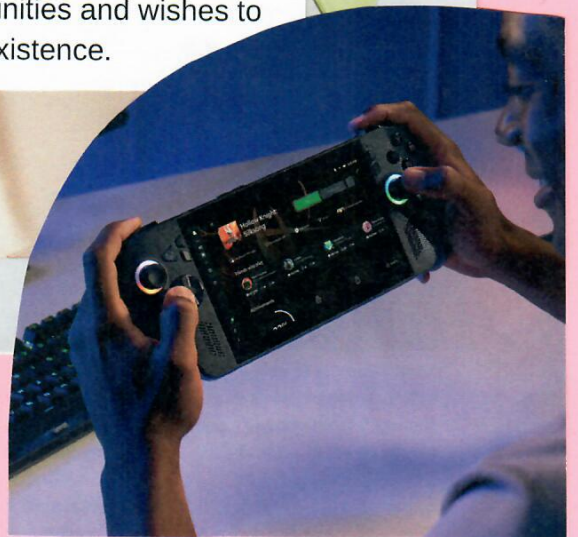
**A WIFE AND
MOTHER**



"I never would have thought that Artificial Intelligence would exist in my lifetime. It is something I will never understand."



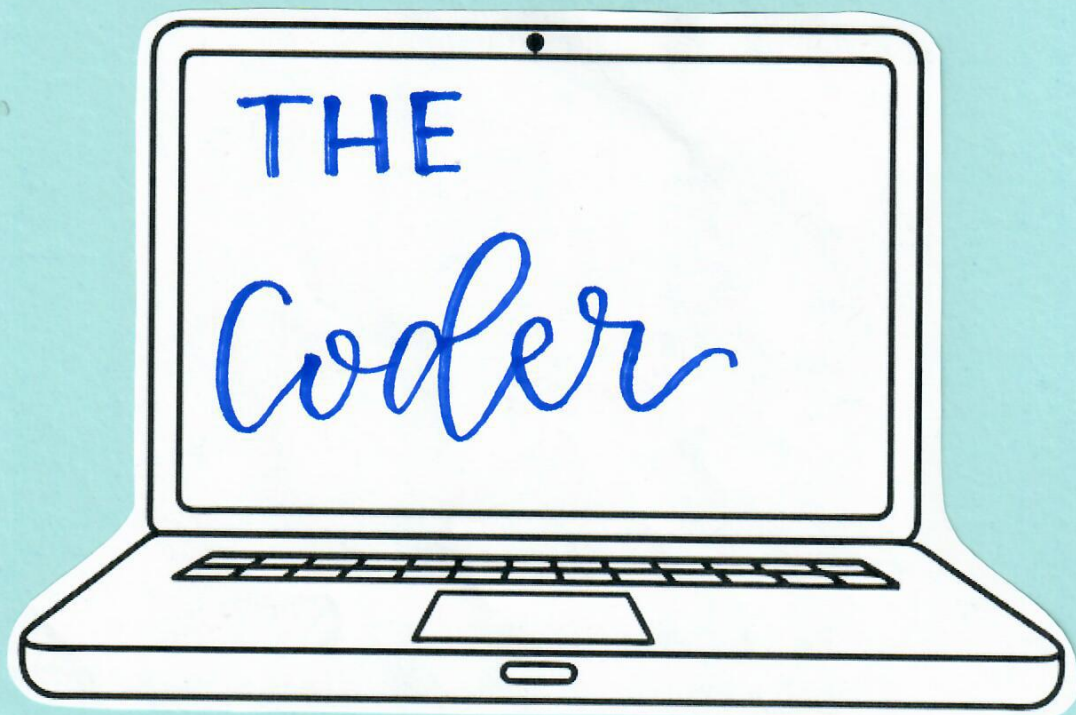
The Tired Millennial is someone who grew up with the internet. He grew up during the early stages of social media, when he could still find community within the digital social climate. Whether it be through video games or early social media sites, the Tired Millennial remembers having a shared reality with the people he interacted with online. As a parent of two Gen Alpha children, he has banned social media for his children. He views the digital social climate as a space that feeds the consumer what they want to hear. As AI joins this space, the Tired Millennial sees further isolation from other communities and wishes to shield his children from this isolating existence.

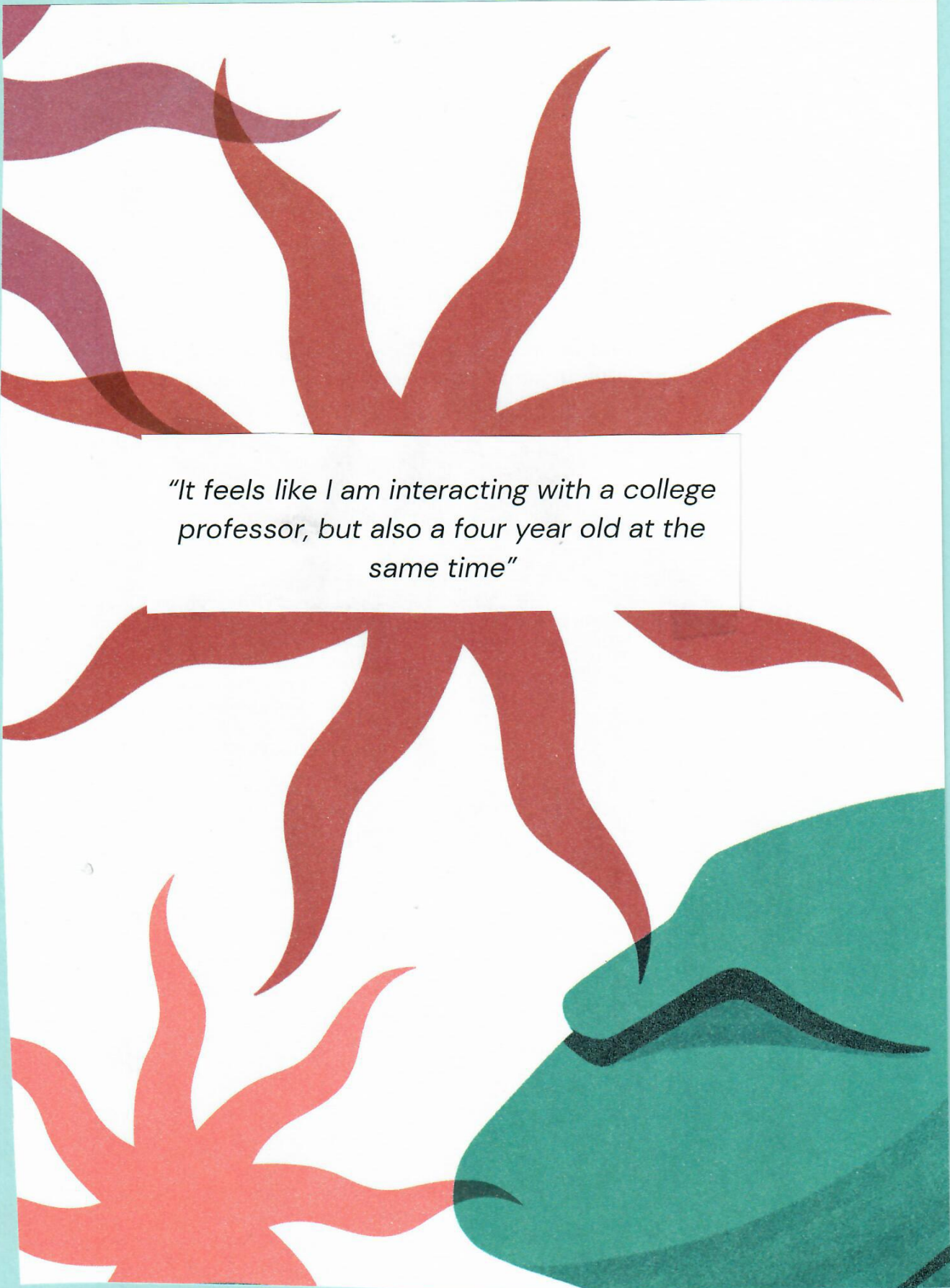




"So, we're at a point where people are unable to recognize what may be true, or is patently false, or maybe not quite correct, or only a truth from a certain point of view. So, that is, I think, the most dangerous non-environmental impact of AI."

The Coder is a young, 23 year old male who recently graduated with a Computer Science degree. When asked how often they use AI, the answer varied. The Coder said he used it more when completing assignments in school, claiming that AI could explain complex mathematical problems better than professors. As a software satellite engineer, The Coder says AI is great for identifying problems in simple codes. The Coder is not on any forms of social media. The Coder still encounters AI in the digital social climate, especially on YouTube. The Coder thinks it is fun to identify AI-generated content. The Coder has even used AI-generated music in his own video games that he created. While The Coder does not think he himself has been impacted negatively by AI within the digital social climate, The Coder does recognize that many of his peers seem to be very dependent on AI for basic tasks. However, the Coder does use AI for tasks such as recipes for meal prep, work out plans, and travel advice.

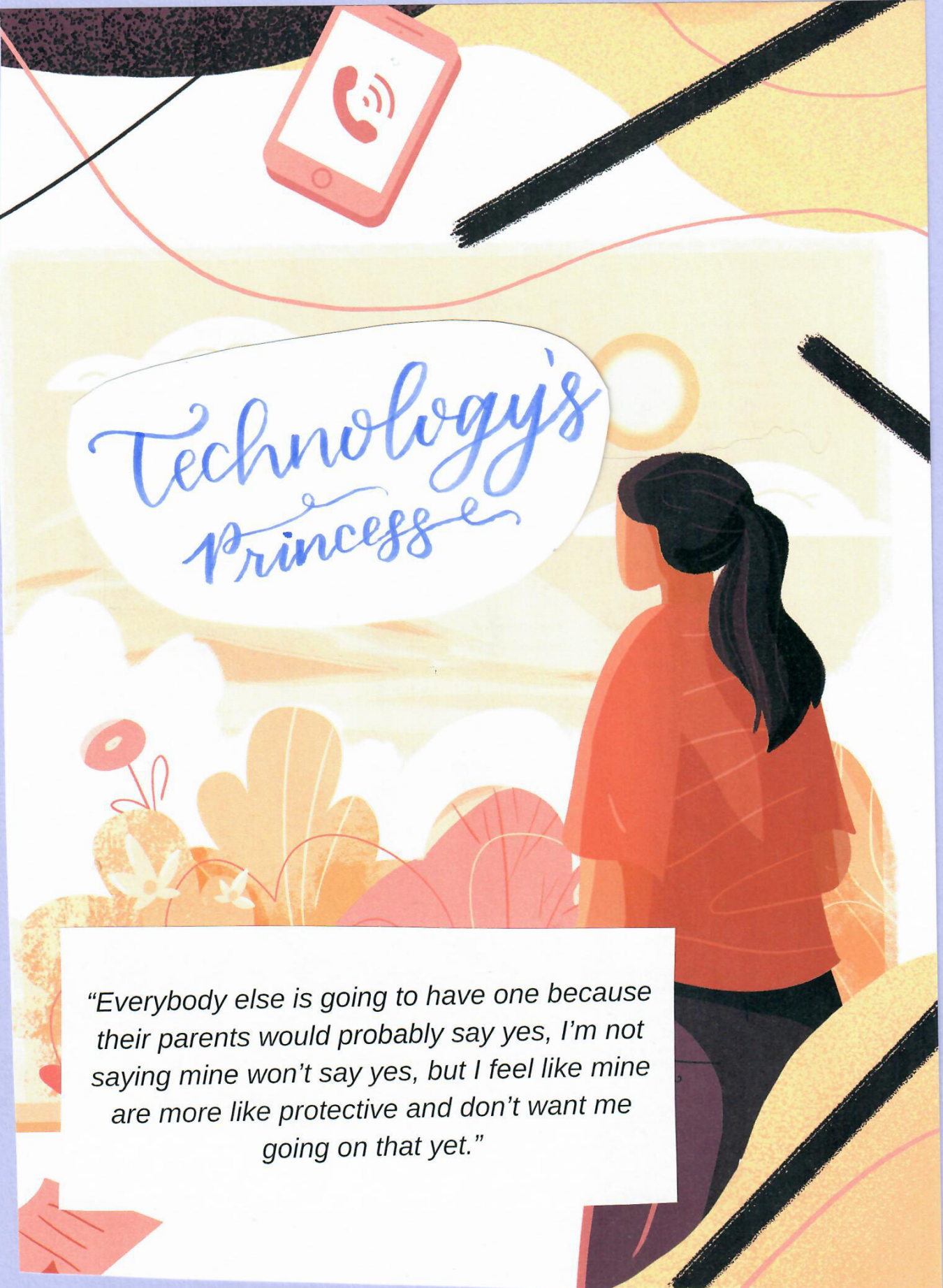




"It feels like I am interacting with a college professor, but also a four year old at the same time"

Technology's Princess is a nine year old girl who has grown up with technology as a regular part of her daily life. Technology is a way for her to communicate with friends and family, a tool for learning, and a source of entertainment. Technology's Princess uses her iPad the most as a way of inspiration. The inspiration can come from a video her friend posted on Zoomerang, a kid-friendly TikTok alternative, or specifically seeking out art tutorials. Technology's Princess is aware that there are unsafe people online because her parents emphasize her safety online. All of her interactions in the digital social climate are monitored by her mom, especially Technology's Princess's text conversations through Facebook Messenger Kids. Technology's Princess is only permitted to use AI with her Dad, typically to ask questions to the "big robot". Technology's Princess feels that talking to people online is "creepy" and it does not feel the same as talking to people in person. However, for a good portion of the interview Technology's Princess emphasized how badly she wanted a phone and social media (Instagram, TikTok) to feel included with her friends. Despite being told why she cannot have a phone or social media, Technology's Princess still desires to be in the digital social climate in order to be in community with her friends.



An illustration of a young woman with dark hair in a ponytail, wearing an orange sweater, seen from the back. She is looking towards a large white speech bubble that contains the title 'Technology's Princess' in blue cursive. Above the speech bubble is a red smartphone with a white call icon. The background is a warm, yellowish-orange landscape with stylized plants and a bright sun. The entire scene is framed by a light purple border.

Technology's Princess

"Everybody else is going to have one because their parents would probably say yes, I'm not saying mine won't say yes, but I feel like mine are more like protective and don't want me going on that yet."

The background of the page is an abstract composition of various shades of teal, green, and orange. On the left, there's a dark teal shape with a white, cloud-like or wave-like detail. Below this, there are more green and orange shapes, some of which are partially obscured by a white, curved shape that resembles a stylized wave or a piece of paper. The overall effect is a layered, collage-like aesthetic.

The Process

The process of making this Zine was definitely unique. At first, Canva was the main source for creation. Canva, however, is very limited and appears very digital. Once we began to move away from technology, the zine finally fell into place. By collecting magazine clippings and printing out pictures for the Zine, the magic of creating something with your hands made it obvious the Zine had to be collage style. This collage concept allowed the actual creation of the zine to go by quickly. This is especially evident as you flip through the Zine. At the beginning, it is aesthetically boring, similar to how AI produces content. As the pages continue, more life comes off the page. I encourage all readers to notice the difference in how they felt viewing the first few content pages versus the interview pages.



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